



Latvian Council of  
Science

# **The CoARA action plan of the Latvian Council of Science for the continuous improvement of research evaluation**

# Background

The Latvian Council of Science (hereinafter - LCS) was established in 1990 as a governmental science management body, and one of its functions is the evaluation of scientific research projects. Since 2022, LCS has become a direct administrative institution under the supervision of the Minister of Education and Science of the Republic of Latvia. LCS's functions, tasks, and competencies include the strategic implementation of science policy and strategic communication, planning and implementation of scientific research programs, providing scientific expertise for the public and private sectors, and promotion and coordination of international scientific cooperation. All these areas of activities require research assessment at various scales and the involvement of various stakeholders.

In 2023 The Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (hereinafter – the Agreement) was signed by the LCS with the aim of improving research assessment - to increase LCS capacity and experience in this field, provide exchange of experience on international level and provide further modernization of assessment procedures to make them more acceptable and understandable to the scientific community.

## LCS Approach and Practice of Research Evaluation

Comparing all fields and types of research assessment covered by the Agreement and its Commitments, according to national legislation and normative acts, LCS provides four types of research evaluation:

- the evaluation of research and innovation projects, their applications within the framework of open calls, the implementation of approved projects, their results, and impact. This process also includes the evaluation of involved scientists and the selection of appropriate experts as external evaluators of research projects;
- the evaluation of the effectiveness and the impact of research programmes and their calls –funding instruments operated by LCS;
- provision of the information and analysis based on data regarding the implementation of the state policy in the field of science and technology development;
- providing an opinion on the validity and purposefulness or reorganization of research institutions; the validity of the inclusion of research institutions in the state register of scientific institutions; the assessment of the research component and the capacity of doctoral study programs in cases of accreditation, licensing, and delegation of promoting rights to universities.

Therefore, LCS assessment activities are mainly focused on evaluation of research projects, as well as the researchers implementing of those projects, research policy instruments, and specific inquiries about the national research landscape. Hence the assessments regarding researcher hiring and careers, the evaluation of research groups, institutions and universities, and research fields fall outside the LCS area of responsibility.

### LCS assessment activities adhere to the following principles:

- assessments are based on peer-review and qualitative evaluation (aligned with CoARA commitment 2), use of bibliometric indicators or other quantitative data remains the responsibility of experts themselves (CoARA commitment 3);
- during the assessment process, the avoidance to use rankings of researchers and research organizations (CoARA commitment 4) is considered, quantitative data (success rate of project applications, results of projects...) are provided only to illustrate the situation and tendencies;
- in addition to direct scientific results and outputs of the research projects (publications, monographs, patents...), the LCS also emphasizes the importance of social impact, the impact of the research on the higher education development and the training of young scientists, and the increase of researchers' scientific capacity. The diversity of the contributions across different scientific fields is also recognized, and the science communication is encouraged (CoARA commitment 1).

## Following activities must be noted as a significant improvement of the LCS assessment procedures:

- during 2018-2022 transition from local and foreign expert pool as evaluators to foreign experts only involvement in the evaluation process of research projects administered by LCS was concluded. This permitted to avoid the conflict of interest, considering limited scale of scientific community of Latvia. Currently only the evaluation of local scale innovation projects, performed in cooperation of research organizations with private organizations or municipalities, is carried out by national experts;
- elaboration of new guidelines and basic principles for the selection of foreign scientific experts for scientific research project application competitions (2023), recognizing that the selection of qualified experts is a crucially critical stage in the process of scientific evaluation of projects, which ensures the quality of this process;
- definition of detailed evaluation criteria, sub-criteria and its explanations as part of the regulations for each call for proposals;
- each project proposal, depending on its size, is evaluated by two to four individual experts. Drawing from individual evaluation reports the consolidated evaluation report is formulated with the consensus of all involved experts. If experts hold conflicting opinions, additional experts are engaged to facilitate the development of the consolidated evaluation report.
- the consultative discussions panels among experts are employed in case of the evaluation of proposals in some types of calls;
- anonymous (without experts' identification) consolidated evaluation report of proposal is made available to submitters after the call is finalized and the decision of awards is made.

## Collaboration

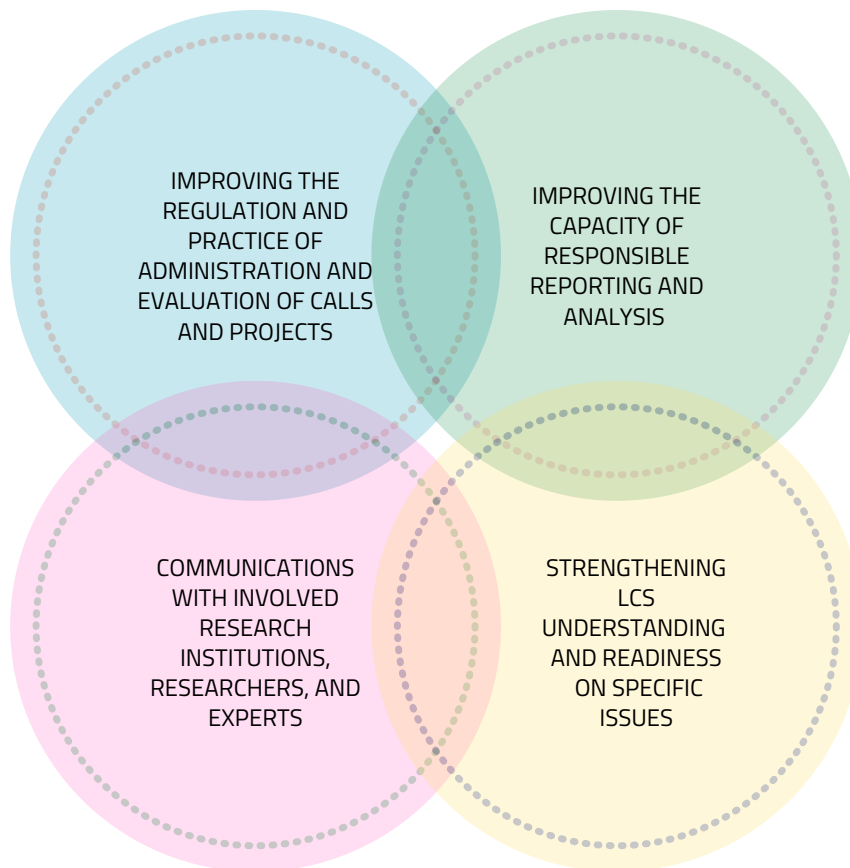
The continuous improvement of the LCS research evaluation exercise relies on the exchange of experiences and best practices, discussions with similar organizations involved in research funding and evaluation, and the acquisition of new insights on these matters. LCS is a member of Science Europe, and representatives of LCS are involved in working groups devoted to such topics as Open Science, Research Culture[1] and Communication. LCS also regularly participates in meetings of European National STI Advisory Councils. The 2025 Spring meeting of the councils will take place in Riga, Latvia and main theme of the meeting will be the use of AI tools in the research activities (e.g. development and evaluation of project proposals, conducting of administrative tasks, proofreading). LCS is a member of European Network of Indicators Designers (ENID) and the representatives of LCS regularly attend the International Science, Technology and Innovation Indicators (STI Indicators) Conference series events. LCS collaborates with Argos as part of the OpenAIRE ecosystem to provide project implementers with opportunities for developing and maintaining Data Management plans and implementing Open Data policies.

## Action plan 2024-2027

Analysis of current LCS practices regarding research evaluation indicates the compliance with CoARA commitments. At the same time, the LCS recognizes that some contradictions with CoARA commitments could be implicit and connected with the administrative supervision of calls and projects or related to the opinions and practices of project implementers (institutions, researchers) and involved experts. LCS places great emphasis on achieving mutual understanding between LCS, research institutions, scientists, and experts regarding project proposal administration, the improvement of evaluation criteria and the supervision of awarded projects. Addressing such shortcomings is crucial to avoiding objections from parties regarding LCS procedures and ensuring a consistent approach and procedure for all applications and projects.

[1] Statement on Research Culture - Empowering Researchers with a Thriving Research System. Science Europe, 2021. DOI: DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.5726893.

Therefore, the LCS Action Plan for 2024-2027 is not merely a series of a separate actions to implement individual CoARA commitments, but rather an ongoing process integrated into the core areas of LCS activities. Its aim is to improve the practices of project application, implementation, evaluation, reporting and related matters. The comparison of the activities carried out by LCS in compliance with the CoARA commitments is a form of permanent self-analysis. Four main directions of actions can be identified, each partially overlapping and interacting with one another:



*The improvement of these actions and self-analysis is directly linked to all CoARA core commitments (1.-4.) and relates to the supporting commitments (5.-10.).*

There is a risk that the positions or actions of partner institutions may contradict CoARA commitments or good practices in research assessment. Such opposing views may also be expressed by individual scientists or institutions involved in research management. In such cases, the LCS must be ready to engage in discussions and advocate for the principles of responsible scientific evaluation in alignment with CoARA commitments. Moreover, national-level cooperation among key partners in the field of research – both funders and implementers – would be desirable for the effective implementation of CoARA commitments and their broader understanding within the scientific community. The LCS is open to such cooperation, however it remains outside the scope of this Action plan. The potential expansion of scope of evaluation activities (evaluation of research groups, institutions and universities, research fields...) delegated to LCS by legislation and normative acts remains outside the scope of this Action Plan. In such cases the development of regulations and evaluation practices will be analysed for compliance with CoARA commitments, Research Integrity and Research Culture constrains.

## Main Directions of LCS Activities (1):

**Improving the regulation and practices of call administration** and project evaluation will involve regular review and adaptation of call/tender regulations and other LCS policies related to research assessment. As routinely LCS develops or refines regulations for each call/tender.

### This will include:



- verifying and ensuring the compliance of regulations with Research Integrity and Research Culture acts;
- strengthening of the use of Narrative CV (2026), especially in cases of projects aimed at advancing researchers' careers. The CV will consist of both factual data - such as education, previous employment, previous research projects, publications, and other measurable achievements - and a narrative section, that explains researcher's motivation and interests;
- restoring the operation of expert panels in calls of Fundamental and Applied Research projects – LCS administrated call with the largest number of applications. The panel is considered as a mechanism that ensures higher-quality assessment of applications compared to individual and consolidated assessments (2026/2027).

**Improving the capacity for responsible reporting and analysis of project calls and their results,** the scientific and social impact of implemented projects, as well as other types of analytical information used for data-based decision making. It will include:

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- the ability to recognize different forms social impact, science communication, the training of young scientists and the enhancement of scientific capacity as key of research outcomes and outputs;
- the responsible use of bibliometric data, ensuring that such data are applied only to illustrate general trends (science fields, funding instrument, national context).
- the complete avoidance of researchers' and projects' rankings. Quantitative data will only be offered at the institutional level allowing for the ranking of research institutions, where it is appropriate;
- an essential part of the proposal evaluation report is a summary of the strengths and weaknesses identified by experts, as well as a summary of their recommendations. This feedback will help future applicants improve their proposals for upcoming calls;
- establishment of an interactive dashboard (based on MS Power BI) to inform the scientific community and the general public about implemented projects and their outputs (2025-2027).

## Main Directions of LCS Activities (2):

**Communications with involved research institutions, researchers and experts** to gather feedback from project applicants, implementers, and scientific experts regarding research project implementation and evaluation. This includes the following:

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- separate annual surveys dedicated to project applicants/implementers (researchers) and experts. Each year the surveys will focus on specific issues:
  - **2024** – overall satisfaction with cooperation with LCS including the submission of project proposals, evaluation and monitoring processes, as well as suggestions for their improvement;
  - **2025** – responsible use of AI in research activities, including the preparation of project proposals, mid-term and final reports, and their scientific evaluation.
  - **2026** – responsible use of indicators in the scientific evaluation of project applications and reports; ensuring a balance between peer-review and quantitative indicators;
  - **2027** – topic to be determined;
- other types of feedback received from research funding institutions (including governmental organizations), research-performing institutions, researchers, experts, industry representatives, other stakeholders and the general public (including mass media).

**Strengthening LCS understanding and readiness on certain issues** in response to current challenges, ensuring the continuous development of competencies, and the ability to address relevant issues.

### This will include:



- strengthening the understanding of AI in research, particularly its use in the research related activities such as preparing research proposals, providing scientific expertise and administrating research projects (2025-2027);
- enhancing skills and opportunities in data management (Open Data, Data Management Plans), strengthening its recognition alongside other types of research results, and incorporating it into research evaluation processes;
- Developing a balanced approach between research openness (Open Science, Open Access, Open Data...) and Research Security (2026-2027). Incorporating the opinions of research procurement institutions will be essential in these cases;
- Conducting bibliometric analysis to address the key questions regarding projects' calls administered by LCS: the correlation between bibliometric indicators of project leaders and proposals evaluations; the accuracy of research result indexing in Scopus/Web of Science databases; and the contribution of research financing instruments to the overall national output (2025-2027).





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